Alfred Russel Wallace



Explorer, naturalist, biologist, geographer, and social reformer Alfred Russel Wallace left school at 14, and trained as a surveyor in London before becoming a teacher. He became fascinated with insects after meeting British entomologist Henry Bates. The pair ventured to the Amazon Basin in 1848 on a four-year collecting expedition. Trips to the Orinoco River and the Malay Archipelago followed. Wallace arrived at the same conclusion as Charles Darwin on the origin of species by natural selection, and they presented their papers jointly in 1858. A world authority on fauna distribution, Wallace also raised awareness about problems caused by human impact on the environment.

Key works

1869 *The Malay Archipelago*

1870 *Contributions to the Theory of Natural Selection*

1876 *The Geographical Distribution of Animals*

1878 *Tropical Nature, and Other Essays*

1880 *Island Life*

See also: Evolution by natural selection • Island biogeography • The distribution of species over space and time • Biomes